CELEBRATING FESTIVALS TRADITIONAL AND MODERN



Tamil Nadu is a land of festivals and the month of January offers particularly rich pickings, the biggest celebration being the harvest festival of Pongal.

January is a very special month for the state of Tamil Nadu. The winter harvest is in, and the occasion is marked with the biggest festival of the Tamils—Pongal, a festival that Tamilians eagerly look forward to all year. Every year, Pongal is being celebrated from January 15 to 18.

The month will also see the observance of Jallikattu—the traditional sport of bull taming and racing—usually held on January 16 each year.

Not only that, January will see the unfurling of the 8th Edition of the Tamil Nadu International Balloon Festival (TNIBF), which is being held from 13 to 15 January, 2023 at Pollachi in Tamil Nadu.

All in all, it's a packed festive calendar in January for Tamil Nadu.



Pongal

A multi-day harvest festival, Pongal is observed by Tamils all over the world. Of course, in Tamil Nadu the celebrations take on a grand scale. Also known as Tai Pongal, it is a celebration of the Tamil New Year, and is held at the beginning of the month of Tai of the Tamil calendar and coincides with harvest festivals all over India which celebrate the Sun God. Pongal sees homes getting cleaned, everyone decking up in the finest clothes, and domestic animals being smeared with sandalwood paste, washed and decorated.

Pongal marks the end of winter and the beginning of Uttarayana, the sun's six-month trip northwards. The festival's name derives from the Tamil word 'pongu' which means 'to boil over' and alludes to the customary dish made from the new harvest of rice boiled in milk with jaggery (raw sugar).

Savoury or salty versions of pongal called ven pongal are also made in addition to the traditional sweet one or sakkara pongal. Since pongal is an offering to the Sun, the preparation is done in the open, in a porch or courtyard bathed in sunlight. On Pongal day, family and friends gather to ask each other the age-old question, "Has the rice boiled?"

Pongal is traditionally cooked in a clay pot that has been decorated with kolam patterns or fastened with a sprig of turmeric root. It is prepared at homes or in communal gatherings like temples or village squares. On the auspicious day, prasadam at Hindu temples in Tamil Nadu consists of portions of sweet pongal.

Each of the four days of Pongal—Bhogi Pongal, Tai Pongal, Mattu Pongal, and Kaanum Pongal—has its own unique significance.

On Bhogi day, people rid themselves of their old belongings and replace them with brand new ones. On Tai or Surya Pongal, the Sun God is honoured. Decorative designs called kolams are drawn on the floor near the front door. Maatu Pongal is a day dedicated to honouring cattle, or 'maatu'. The cattle are given flower garlands, beads, and bells to make their already attractive horns stand out even more. On Kaanum Pongal, families gather for a festive feast. Traditional folk dances, such as Mayilattam and Kolattam, are performed on this day. Games such as Jallikattu (with bulls), vazhukku maram (a slippery pole), mallar kambam (a fusion of gymnastics and yoga), Uri Adithal (breaking a hanging mud pot while blindfolded), and Kabaddi are played during Pongal. Sarees, ethnic jewellery, handicrafts, and pottery are on display and sale at Pongal Mela or festivals across Tamil Nadu.

